FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

A young man, who used to be mortally afraid of heights, suddenly signs up for a skydiving course in Dubai—and thinks nothing of jumping off a plane. A 65-year-old homemaker in Delhi, Sunita Ahuja, goes back to studies—after over 45 years. By now, she has completed three full online courses in English literature. A couple in Hyderabad-Secunderabad, Srikanth Arval and Prabhjoth, find that the pandemic has disrupted their thriving florist business. What do they do? Take an entirely different line—investing their savings, and they now run a boutique homestay outside the Tadoba Tiger Reserve in Maharashtra. Bakshish Dean, a veteran of the hospitality industry in Delhi, decides to go on not one but 20 holidays with his family and even buys himself a car that is way beyond his budget.

What's common between them? The thing they are reaching out for is, literally, their dream. A piece of real estate that we all carry inside of us. Something that we all tend to keep for a later day—a matter of infinite deferment and procrastination. It could be realised in the form of a vacation, a new job, or a hobby—but, at its core, it is the manifestation of an inner transformation. What brought it about? The shock to our ordered, predictable lives that the pandemic brought. Suddenly, we are all too aware of mortality—the idea that life is fundamentally something that can be extinguished at any moment. A sense of impermanence, of physical health and our finances, now haunts us constantly. And it has brought about what may seem a paradoxical reaction at first. People are splurging, living it up, taking the plunge into the unknown. As if everyone is now driven by the acknowledgement that You Only Live Once, better known by its acronym YOLO. If we were saving up for a rainy day, that rainy day is right here.

The idea for this week's cover story took birth when a colleague talked about a radical, unexpected behavioural change she had seen in a few of her acquaintances. And we realised that almost everyone could identify with that—at the experiential level. Could there actually be a broader pattern, we wondered. A kind of a psychological corner that humanity has collectively turned? We decided to explore this intriguing idea. As Senior Associate Editor Sonali Acharjee cast out her net and colleagues elsewhere came up with contributions, we found the examples multiplying easily. This, indeed, was not a random phenomenon. From all over the map, cases came in of people making radical life choices—accompanied by a new willingness and capacity for risk-taking.



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So, there was the 48-year-old, stay-at-home dad and former merchant navy officer Arvind Ganga, taking off to no less than Antarctica. After two full years of living in isolation, with our worlds turned still, we all know what he means when he says, "Not being able to travel during the pandemic was extremely difficult on me. I felt deprived of something essential in my life. If I had let Covid hold me back, I would have missed out on one of the most eye-opening, beautiful experiences of my life." Indeed, the more we heard the voices, the more we were struck by the commonality of sentiment. There were other tell-tale signs, too, of changed behaviour. Luxury car-maker Mercedes Benz reported its highest sales ever this year, and the demand surprisingly came from smaller cities like Guwahati and Surat. Almost everyone had seen death up close—many of us lost family and friends. And the collective experience of grief and shock on such a planetary scale has almost genetically altered our outlook on life. Something we could not even see changed us.

What we are doing in response is essentially a kind of coping. Mental health experts attest to the phenomenon. Says Mumbai-based psychiatrist Dr Kedar Tilwe: "People want to find a silver lining to the pandemic. The sudden realisation that life is short makes many want to do more things that bring them peace and make them happy." The world has seen this before somewhat. Soon after the end of World War II, there was a boom in the sales of consumer goods, many of which were considered luxuries at the time, like cars and washing machines. Undoubtedly, the world has changed so much that it is never going back to what it was. The process of globalisation that started in the middle of the previous century is now in reverse gear. Added to that is the fact that we have reached inside of ourselves to find a 'new me'—and through that path of discovery, we are crafting a new world outside of us.

So, if you haven't joined the party yet, do so. YOLO.



(Aroon Purie)